

The Plague

The rec room of I.S.P. Base 45 had been painted neon colors that made every sober thought seem faintly embarrassed. Zephyr had done it during a three-hour window when Bás was on an off-site meeting, and by the time Bás returned, the concrete walls were already a committed act of psychedelic violence. The argument that followed lasted twenty minutes. The paint stayed.

It was early afternoon when Zephyr was working through his skull-mask polishing ritual, moving to a beat only he could hear through his internal comm. His body, built like something that had decided physics were a suggestion, bobbed with the rhythm, and the whole room trembled very slightly around him, the dust motes doing their best to get out of the way.

In the corner farthest from the windows, Bás Eagla sat in the particular stillness that came naturally to him. Not meditative stillness, not sleepy stillness, the stillness of something that was watching. His skull-adorned mask was angled toward the table in front of him, but his bright green eyes, the only color his body offered the room, were fixed on his partner.

There was, if you knew where to look, a fondness in the way he watched Zephyr's absurdity. A man who didn't care at all would have left by now.

"You know," Zephyr's voice broke the silence, synthesized, huge, and cheerful as a minor catastrophe, "the base needs more bass. The whole mountain needs more bass. The structural engineers were cowards."

"The structural integrity of the facility disagrees," Bás replied. His voice was the opposite of Zephyr's in every possible way: low, cold, dry as old stone. "As do my vertebrae."

"Your vertebrae are drama queens, Bás."

"My vertebrae are the only reason I remain upright. I have some affection for them."

"Pfft." Zephyr resumed polishing, his massive body swaying. "You're just mad 'cuz you can't dance. Two left feet. Or, wait, do you even have feet under that fog-dress?"

The temperature in the room dropped approximately two degrees. It wasn't the air conditioning.

"Zephyr."

"Right, right. Shutting up. Sheesh."

He didn't shut up, but he did transition to humming, which was close enough.

The moment before the intercom crackled to life was so ordinary it almost hurt to think about afterward. They were just there, the two of them, in their strange equilibrium. One enormous and neon and endlessly moving. One lean and dark and endlessly still. Benny's intercom produced its signature sound, not a buzz, not a chime, but something like a kazoo being played by a duck with urgent news, and broke the afternoon in half.

"Agents Zephyr and Eagla! To my office, pretty-please-with-gummy-bears-on-top! I've got something shiny!"

Zephyr was on his feet before the quacking finished. "Shiny! That's my language!"

Bás rose with more deliberation, unfolding from the chair like a long shadow detaching itself from a wall. He looked at the neon ceiling for a moment, the way a man looks at rain before stepping into it.

"Heavens preserve us," he said quietly, mostly to himself, "from Benny's shiny."

—

Benny Mischief's office existed in a permanent state of creative collapse. Wires descended from the ceiling in festive curtains. Three-dimensional schematics rotated in the air, their colors bleeding into each other at the edges. On the main console, Chuckles the teddy bear sat wearing a small foil hat, overseeing the chaos with one loose eye and the equanimity of a creature that had seen too much to be surprised by anything.

Benny himself was behind his desk, both hands wrapped around something that appeared to be a coffee mug bolted to a car battery. His thick-rimmed glasses had fogged slightly. His hair was doing several things at once.

"Fellas! Just in time! Behold, the Perpetual Perk-Me-Up!" He beamed the beam of a man who was about to be wrong about something. "It draws ambient neutrinos from the air and maintains your beverage at the perfect temperature. Forever. In theory. Right now it's flash-boiling the coffee and I'm fairly sure it's been in contact with dolphins."

He pressed a button. The mug screamed. A geyser of boiling coffee erupted from the top and painted the ceiling brown, narrowly clearing Zephyr's head.

A brief silence.

"...Needs work," Benny admitted, and dropped the device into a bin already overflowing with its predecessors.

"Boss," Zephyr said admiringly, staring at the spreading stain above them, "you are a genuine menace to infrastructure."

"The summons, Benny," Bás said.

Benny's grin snapped off. His face did the thing it occasionally did, the theater falling away to reveal the actual person underneath, older and more serious than the performance suggested. He leaned forward. He laced his fingers together.

"We got a call," he said. "From someone large, blue, and extremely unhappy about it."

The effect on the room was immediate. Zephyr stopped posing. Bás's head tilted, the green eyes inside his mask sharpening into something that wasn't quite alarm but was adjacent to it.

"Thaldrim," Bás said. Not a question.

"Thaldrim," Benny confirmed. "He's on the coast. Hour's drive. Wants a meet. Says it's urgent." He held up one hand before Bás could speak. "I know. I know what you're about to say. His pride is, "

"Thicker than a mountain range," Bás said. "He would rather swallow the sea than ask for help. If he is asking, it is not because he has run out of options. It is because what he is dealing with is beyond options."

"My point exactly!" Benny said, spinning to his console with renewed energy. "Which is why this is urgent, and which is why, and hear me out, hear me out, it's a perfect training opportunity. You're taking the recruits."

The temperature drop this time was more pronounced.

Zephyr, to his credit, looked delighted. "The newbies! Weather-boy and the animal-whisperer! We could make it educational! Field trip energy!"

"No," Bás said.

One word. No inflection. The kind of no that closes doors and salts the earth behind them.

"Benny." Bás turned to face their supervisor fully, and there was a quality in his stillness that made the room feel smaller. "Thaldrim is not a lesson. He is an elemental force. He is older than most of the countries on this planet, and he is calling because something has genuinely frightened him. Parker cannot regulate his power when he is calm. In a situation that frightens experienced agents, he will cloud the sky. And Whisperwind, she is composed, yes, but composure is not the same as readiness. That is not a test for a recruit."

Benny held the stare. He didn't wilt under it the way most people did, which was one of the reasons he was their supervisor and not the other way around.

"Bás," he said gently. "My sensors say it's a clear coast. You and Zephyr will be there to run interference if anything goes sideways. And they need this. Not the danger, the

reality. They've been training against simulations. They need to understand what's actually out there." He paused. "What's the worst that could happen?"

Bás looked at him for a long, heavy moment.

"You," he said, "of all people, should never ask that question."

Another beat.

"...Fine. But if Parker's weather responds to his fear before I can contain the situation, or if Whisperwind makes contact with something dangerous in her attempts to use her ability, it falls on you." He was already moving toward the door. "Zephyr. Get the Jeep. I will fetch the children."

Zephyr pumped a massive fist as soon as Bás's robes disappeared around the doorframe.

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The I.S.P. Jeep was built for terrain that hated being driven on, and the landscape between Base 45 and the Chilean coast provided plenty of it. Zephyr drove with the enthusiasm of someone who had found his natural medium. The music coming from the speakers was technically electronic, but the bass frequencies were more a geological event than a sound. Bás sat in the passenger seat the way he always sat, absolutely still, a column of shadow while the world bounced around him.

In the back, Abraher Parker sat pressed against the window as if hoping it would absorb him. He was twenty-three years old and looked, in this moment, significantly younger. His chestnut hair was doing its usual thing, slightly windswept regardless of conditions, as if a personal atmosphere followed him. His stormy grey eyes moved from rock to rock outside the window with the nervous precision of someone who had been taught that staying alert meant staying safe.

He had learned that in an orphanage in New York, where staying alert had meant something different. Where the threat was never physical, just relentless, the particular cruelty of kids who had already been abandoned and had learned to use that as a weapon on anyone smaller, or quieter, or stranger. Abraher had been all three.

He sat now in an I.S.P. Jeep on his way to meet an elemental ocean god and he was thinking, without meaning to, about how the word mistake had been said to him in so many different ways over so many years that he could no longer hear it without his whole body bracing.

He didn't notice the way his fingertips sparked with small, involuntary static. But Elara did.

Elara Whisperwind sat beside him, her fiery red hair flat against the seat. Her hands were in her lap, clasped together tightly enough that her knuckles had gone pale. She was watching the back of Bás's masked head with the focused attention of someone analyzing a problem, which was how Elara generally approached things she found frightening. If you could understand the shape of it, you could manage the feeling of it. Usually.

She had grown up in a house with money and silence, on an island where the sea was everywhere and the social expectations were claustrophobic. She had learned composure as a survival strategy before she understood what it was. Now it was simply part of her, not coldness, though people sometimes mistook it for coldness, but the habit of not showing what she wasn't sure she had the right to show.

"So," Abraher said, finally, over the music. "Thaldrim. Is he... what's he actually like?"

Zephyr barked a laugh. "Kid, 'nice' is cocoa on a cold day. Thaldrim is the ocean. He's big, wet, and has the warmth of a continent. Don't worry, he loves me."

"He tolerates you," Bás said without turning around, "because he respects me."

"Six of one."

Elara leaned forward slightly. "Agent Eagla. Every I.S.P. brief describes Thaldrim as neutral and isolated, a Tier-1 Elemental who has not requested contact in recorded history. Why would he change that now?"

Bás turned then, just enough to let his green eyes find hers in the mirror. "That," he said, "is precisely why we are going. Not to answer the question, Whisperwind. To be worthy of it. Stay sharp. Watch everything. Trust your tutors." A pause. "And keep your abilities at rest unless I authorize them. Both of you."

Abraher swallowed. The sky outside the window was perfectly clear. His hands, when he pressed them together in his lap, were shaking.

They reached the coast in the long gold of the afternoon, when the sun was still above the horizon but already thinking about leaving. The beach was not beautiful. It was a volcanic shore, all black rock and salt-white foam, the kind of place that had been battered by weather for so long it had stopped caring about it. The waves hit the rocks with a sound like sustained argument.

They left the Jeep on the cliff road and climbed down to the shore on foot. The wind was cold and immediate. Abraher pulled his hoodie tighter. Above them, the sky was clear, too clear, the kind of transparent blue that felt thin, like it was only barely committed to the idea of being a sky.

"He's late," Zephyr announced, planting both enormous hands on his hips and surveying the horizon. "Unprofessional, even for a demigod."

"He is not late," Bás said. He was standing on a low flat rock, his dark robes perfectly still in a wind that was throwing Abraher's hair into his face. "He is already here. He is deciding."

Abraher frowned. "Deciding what?"

"Whether we are worth the effort of rising."

The waves stopped.

Not gradually, not like a tide going out, all at once, as if someone had pressed a button. One moment: the full, surging percussion of the Atlantic. The next: a silence so total it pressed against their ears like a hand.

Elara's composure cracked, just slightly. Her voice, when she spoke, was barely audible. "The tide... look at the tide."

The water was not receding. It was fleeing. Hundreds of meters of wet seabed exposed themselves in seconds, gasping fish, startled starfish, the strange architecture of a world that was usually hidden. The exposed rock glistened. The smell hit them all at once, brine and deep water and something ancient underneath.

Above them, Abraher's clear sky disappeared.

It wasn't a gradual cloud cover. The clouds arrived the way Abraher's moods did when he wasn't controlling them, all at once, from everywhere, bruise-dark and churning. He felt it before he understood it, that tight-chest feeling of a storm coming from inside him, and he yanked his hands to his sides and squeezed his eyes shut.

"That is not you," Bás said, sharply. "Parker. Open your eyes. That is not you."

Abraher opened his eyes. Bás had turned around and was looking directly at him, the green gaze steady and certain. Abraher believed him, and the tight feeling loosened slightly.

Then the ocean rose.

It didn't crash. It simply... stood. The water gathered itself into a wall at the horizon, a moving architecture, blue-dark and enormous, lit from within by a bioluminescent pulse that turned the churning foam green and silver. It rose until it blocked the horizon entirely, and then it kept rising, and from its center, a shape emerged.

He was three times Zephyr's height, which meant he was approximately the size of a reasonable building. His skin was the deep, shifting blue of open water in the dark, armor of coral and barnacle and forge-worked sea-iron covering his chest and arms. His hair moved in currents that didn't exist above the water. His trident, which he held loosely at his side like a walking stick, pulsed with a light the color of deep ocean bioluminescence.

His eyes found the group on the shore with the unhurried precision of something that had been looking at this particular stretch of coastline since before the first humans walked past it.

Abraher made a small, choked sound and sat down involuntarily. Then, with more commitment, he fainted, crumpling sideways onto the wet black rock in a way that would leave a mark.

Elara did not faint. She stood completely still, her mouth slightly open, every animal in a half-mile radius suddenly, instinctively silent, because she had gone so still herself that her power had simply stopped broadcasting. It was the stillness of someone whose entire nervous system had pressed pause.

"Okay," Zephyr said, in a voice stripped of almost all its usual performance. "That's... a bit more dramatic than I remembered."

Thaldrim stepped forward. Each footfall sent a tremor through the rock they were standing on. He looked at the boy on the ground. He looked at the frozen girl. He looked at the two masked figures with the evaluating patience of an ocean deciding whether to cooperate with this particular piece of coast.

Then he looked at Bás.

Bás had not moved. He stood on his flat rock with his robes still and his green eyes open and his head slightly bowed, not in submission but in the particular angle of someone who is listening with their whole body.

"Lord Thaldrim," he said. "You honor us."

The voice that came back was not a sound. It was a vibration, a frequency that bypassed the ears and arrived directly in the chest, in the teeth, in the bones of the feet.

"BÁS EAGLA. ZEPHYR."

"Thal-baby!" Zephyr's voice had recovered its register, though not quite its full wattage. He struck a heroic pose, which looked genuinely heroic given the scale differential. "Looking fantastic as always. The hair is very seaweed-forward this season. I'm into it."

Thaldrim's expression did not change. But something in it, a micro-tightening around the deep-sea eyes, suggested that Zephyr had been filed under 'predictable, manageable, ultimately acceptable.'

"ENOUGH."

The spray that hit Zephyr was targeted. A ten-foot wave from a previously calm tide pool, aimed with a precision that was somehow more intimidating than random violence.

Zephyr stood there, dripping, the emoji on his mask cycling briefly through various expressions before settling on something between amused and sheepish.

Thaldrim turned to face Bás fully.

"I... REQUIRE. ASSISTANCE."

The words came out the way a mountain must feel when it acknowledges erosion, not easily, not quickly, and with the clear implication that this was the only time it would ever be said.

Bás didn't let the moment sit unacknowledged. "I know how much it costs you to say that," he said, his voice quiet and direct, without ceremony. "We are here. Tell us."

Thaldrim's colossal brow furrowed. It was the most human thing about him, the way his expression could carry something that was unmistakably distress, if distress had been born at the bottom of the ocean and lived there for several centuries.

"MY WATERS. THEY ARE WRONG. POISONED. NEAR THE BALEARES. THE ISLAND YOUR PEOPLE CALL MALLORCA."

He raised one blue hand, and in the sky above them, something shifted, a change in the color of the light, a new weight in the air.

"A VIRUS. A PLAGUE. ARTIFICIAL. IT KILLS. THE FISH... THE KRAKEN... THE OLDEST ONES... THEY DIE." His grip on the trident tightened. The ocean behind him darkened. "AND MY WAVES... THEY CARRY IT. THEY SPREAD IT. MY OWN DOMAIN IS BECOME THE INSTRUMENT OF THEIR DEATH, AND I CAN DO NOTHING. MY OATH BINDS ME FROM THAT SHORE."

He pointed the trident toward them. It was not a threat. It was a plea given the only shape he knew.

"YOU CAN GO WHERE I CANNOT. I TRUST FEW. I TRUST YOU. YOUR SHADOWS ARE AS DEEP AND OLD AS MY TRENCHES, BÁS EAGLA." He turned his gaze to Zephyr, a beat. "AND YOU. YOUR NOISE IS A PLAGUE UNTO ITSELF. BUT YOUR HEART IS WITHOUT COMPROMISE. FIND THE SOURCE. END IT."

Behind them, someone made a quiet groaning sound. Abraher had regained consciousness and was lying on his back on the rock looking at the storm clouds above him, his own clouds, it turned out, because without the anchor of Bás's earlier command his fear had bled back into the sky.

Elara crouched beside him without being asked. "Breathe," she said, low and matter-of-fact, the way she spoke to injured animals. "We're all still alive."

"That's a god," Abraher whispered.

"Yes."

"That's an actual god."

"An elemental. Technically distinct." She put her hand over his. "Breathe."

He breathed. The clouds above them, his clouds, began, slowly, to thin.

Bás watched this, and something in his posture shifted incrementally. He turned back to Thaldrim.

"It will be done," he said.

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The drive back was the quietest the Jeep had ever been. Zephyr had turned the music off, which felt significant. The landscape rolled past, the dry mountains, the thin afternoon light, the absolute indifference of the Andean rock to everything that was happening to the small creatures moving across it.

Abraher sat with his hands on his knees, staring at them. He'd stopped shaking. What was left was quieter and harder to name, the particular stillness that follows finding out something about the scale of the world.

Elara sat beside him. She wasn't touching him, but she was close enough that he could feel the warmth of her proximity, and she was watching him the way she watched things she was worried about, which was with the fixed, quiet attention of someone who had learned that attention itself was a form of care.

Benny was in his chair when they filed into the command center, Chuckles in his lap, his feet on the desk. He took one look at all four of them and put his feet on the floor.

"So," he said carefully. "How'd it go?"

"We have a mission," Bás said. "Mallorca. Biological agent in the ocean. The source is on land."

Benny's face did its thing, the theater collapsing, the real man emerging. He was already at his console, his fingers moving. "Mallorca." He pulled up a file. The screen filled with flags and classifications and a heading that read: SOVEREIGN STATE OF

MALLORCA, TOTALITARIAN / PURITY DOCTRINE / ANTI-POWERED / BLACK BASTION PRISON.

He was quiet for a moment in a way that wasn't comfortable.

"This isn't a stroll, team," he said, his voice entirely different from the one that had announced the Perpetual Perk-Me-Up. "The SSM hunts registered powered individuals on sight. They have the most sophisticated anti-power infrastructure on the planet. The moment you land, you're targets."

"So we sneak in," Zephyr said. "A little strategic chaos. My specialty."

"That's the strange part." Benny clicked a final key, and a new document appeared on screen, official letterhead, clear language, a formal acceptance. "Standard I.S.P. diplomatic entry request for 'oceanographic anomaly investigation.' I sent it as a formality. They should have buried it in bureaucratic silt for six months."

"And?" Elara said. Her first word since the beach.

"They accepted. Immediately. Full diplomatic access. Red carpet." He rubbed his chin. "The SSM does not do this. The SSM does not cooperate with anyone, ever, about anything."

The silence that followed had texture to it.

"It is a trap," Bás said.

"Or they're desperate," Benny said. "Or both. A trap set by desperate people is still a trap, but it tells you something." He looked at the screen, then at his team. "Either way, the sea is dying. Thaldrim has asked. The mission stands." He took a breath. "You go at 08:00. Full diplomatic cover. I'm getting you PCR-IDs, Powered Citizen Registry cards. Mallorcan government issue. You wear them at all times."

Abraher, who had been listening from the back of the room, raised his head.

Benny looked at him. "You're off probation," he said. "Both of you. This is real now." He tried on his usual grin, but it didn't quite fit right at the moment. "Get some sleep."

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The IDs arrived in a small case that Benny handled with the careful attention he usually reserved for things that were either very delicate or very dangerous. He opened it on the hangar floor at 07:45, and the four laminated cards inside looked mundane enough, photographs, numbers, classifications in a bureaucratic font, until you read what was printed on them.

Zephyr examined his with the enthusiasm of someone at a gallery opening. "ZC-o88-TANGO. Offensive, High-Threat. Status: RED, RESTRICTED." He tilted the card, looking at the photo. "This lighting is a civil rights violation, Benny. I look like a very intimidating blueberry."

Bás took his card without comment. He read it once and set it in an interior pocket of his robe, and did not look at it again.

Elara read hers with the focused attention she brought to everything. "EW-451-FLORA. Non-Combatant. GREEN, COMPLIANT." She looked up. "They've rated me as harmless."

"Let them," Bás said.

Abraher was last. His hand was steady when he reached for the card, but Benny kept a hand on the case for just a moment before releasing it, and the brief hesitation was enough to make everyone look.

"AP-773-STORM," Abraher read. His voice was flat and careful. "Unstable, Elemental. Emotion-Linked." He stopped. He started again. "Status: YELLOW, UNDER REVIEW." A pause. "Why yellow?"

"It's the combination," Benny said. He was choosing his words with unusual care. "Unstable and Emotion-Linked together. Green means you're controllable. Red means you're a weapon they know how to point. Yellow means..." He exhaled. "Yellow means they're scared of you. They don't know what you do until you feel something strongly enough to do it, and they can't predict what that will be. To their system, that's the scariest classification."

Abraher looked at the card for a long time. Then he looked out the hangar door at the brightening sky.

"Okay," he said.

That was all. Just okay. But Elara, standing beside him, noted the way his jaw set, and the way his shoulders didn't slump, and she decided that was something.

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The jet was a study in wasted luxury. Leather seats, temperature-controlled air, the faint smell of money. No one appreciated any of it.

Zephyr was reclined with his feet up and his mask cycling through expressions that suggested he was in the middle of a complex internal monologue. Bás sat in the darkest available corner, not by coincidence, staring at the middle distance with the fixed, inward look that meant he was thinking hard about something he hadn't decided to share yet.

Elara and Abraher had claimed two seats toward the rear. Abraher was holding his ID card, turning it over and over, the laminate catching light. On the tray beside him, a cup of water vibrated in a slow, persistent tremor that had nothing to do with turbulence.

"They already know what we can do," Abraher said. His voice was low, meant only for Elara. The cabin lights flickered as he said it, once, brief.

Elara watched the lights come back. She reached over and covered his hand, the one holding the card, with hers. Not because she'd made a decision to, but because it was the obvious thing and she trusted obvious things.

"It's designed to make you afraid before you land," she said. "They want you walking off the plane already half-defeated. Don't let a laminated card do their job for them."

He looked down at their hands. He turned his over so they were palm to palm. "What if it's accurate?" he said. "The classification. What if I actually am, "

"Abraher." She said it the way you say someone's name when you need them to stop and actually hear you. "You have spent your whole life being told you're a variable that makes people nervous. That doesn't make it true. It makes it their problem."

From the front of the cabin: "She's right, weather-boy!" Zephyr's voice boomed with what, for him, passed as restraint. "It's just a piece of plastic. And we don't do what the plastic tells us."

"We do not pull on the leash, Zephyr." Bás's voice came from his corner, quiet and sharp, without him looking up. "Not yet. In Mallorca, that document tells them who to watch, who to suppress, and who to eliminate if the situation warrants it. Yellow means they will be watching Abraher specifically, because they cannot predict him." His green eyes moved to the back of the cabin. "Which means you, Parker, must be more controlled than you have ever been. Not less. More."

Abraher took a breath. He nodded once.

Bás looked at him for a moment in a way that was hard to read through the mask, and then he looked away, which, from Bás, was its own form of acknowledgment.

The jet descended, breaking through cloud cover to reveal Mallorca laid out below them: terracotta and blue water and the brutal white geometry of the Serra de Tramuntana in the north. It looked, from altitude, like paradise. Most traps did.

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Guide Katerina met them on the tarmac in a white suit so pristine it suggested she had manifested fully formed from a press release. Her smile was the kind of smile that had been practiced into a tool. The six guards flanking her had rifles and postures that were doing a lot of the communication for them.

Zephyr stepped off the ramp first, because Zephyr always stepped off first, and the effect of him, the six-foot-seven psychedelic enormity, the neon suit under the bright Mallorcan sun, the skull mask fixed in its permanent half-grin, on the armed and uniformed receiving committee was immediate and satisfying. Two guards took an involuntary step back. One muttered something in Spanish that ended in words Zephyr had heard before in multiple countries and multiple contexts.

"This 'freak,'" Zephyr said pleasantly, to no one in particular, "is a high-level diplomatic envoy. And this suit is couture. Look it up."

"Agent." Bás appeared at his shoulder, a column of shadow in the bright sun, his voice below the ambient noise so only Zephyr could hear. "Diplomacy. Now."

Katerina's smile didn't waver. It was impressive. "Agents of the International Security Program. Welcome to the Sovereign State of Mallorca. I am Guide Katerina. It is my honor to assist you."

Her eyes made a circuit of all four of them, and on Abraher's yellow-status ID they paused for exactly half a second before moving on. Abraher noticed. Elara noticed Abraher notice.

They were put in a vehicle that was armored in ways that implied hospitality was not the primary concern. As they moved through Nova Palma, Katerina performed what appeared to be a prepared speech about architecture and civic pride.

Bás looked out the window. He did not look at the buildings. He looked at the banners.

They hung from every surface: stark, confident, enormous. 'A Power is a Burden. Report the Unregistered.' 'Purity is Strength. Strength is Order.' And one that Bás looked at for several seconds before turning away, a stylized poster in which a shadowy, glowing-eyed figure cowered in an alley while a family of 'pure' citizens stood in triumphant sunlight above it. The shadow-figure wore a long dark robe. Its eyes, the only bright thing about it, were a sinister green.

He turned away from the window.

Abraher had sunk low in his seat. The window beside him had fogged from the inside, which was impossible given the temperature and the sealed car. Katerina's eyes touched it and tightened.

"We are not here for the tour," Bás said, his voice cutting cleanly through Katerina's narration. "We are here to investigate a biological contamination event in your coastal waters."

The practiced smile fell so completely it was almost architectural, the structural failure of an expression built on pretense meeting something real. Katerina went still. Then she pulled out a datapad, and her thumbs moved fast, and her voice when she spoke again was entirely different: clipped and cold and genuinely furious.

"Chyort," she said. A Russian curse, short and sharp. "You're certain? A virus? Artificial?"

"That is our information."

"Dammit." She was typing hard. "We thought he was contained." She looked up, and the guide's mask was completely gone. What was underneath was a competent, frightened official. "There was an inmate. Black Bastion. A bio-terrorist, his ability

allows him to manufacture plagues through direct contact with organic material. Any organic material. We held him in a dry cell, isolated, no humidity. His classification was Omega-Level Pathogen."

"Escaped?" Bás said.

"Three days ago. A prisoner transfer was ambushed, we believed he died in the response. If he survived and reached the sewer system..." She didn't finish.

"He reached the ocean," Bás said.

Katerina barked an order to the driver. The SUV lurched, changed direction, and began to climb.

"Where are we going?" Elara asked.

"To Black Bastion," Katerina said. Her voice, now that the pretense was gone, had the flat efficiency of someone operating in emergency mode. "To the source."

The road climbed through military checkpoints and into the grey stone severity of the Serra de Tramuntana. The sunny logic of Nova Palma gave way to something harder and older. The air thinned. Abraher's breath started coming with more effort, and he gripped the door handle and said nothing.

"The dampening fields start this far out," Zephyr said, with none of his usual performance. "Whole mountain is one big suppression zone."

Abraher pressed his hand flat against his sternum. "I can feel it," he said quietly.

Elara watched his face. She didn't say anything, but she didn't look away.

The prison came around the final bend without warning. It didn't rise into view, it was simply there, carved directly into the mountainside, a massive brutalist wound in the rock. Black concrete and dull metal and the hum of the dampening pylons, which you felt in your sinuses before you heard them. Anti-power emitters lined the perimeter in rows that made the air shimmer with a sickly, visible quality, like heat coming off something that had been damaged.

"Welcome to Black Bastion," Katerina said. "The most secure anti-powered facility on Earth."

The gates ground open. The darkness inside them was absolute.

The checkpoint inside the gate was a cave of grey light and hostility. The moment Abraher stepped out of the SUV and tried, reflexively, to call a spark to his fingertips, a habit he didn't even consciously realize he had, a small private reassurance that he was still himself, nothing happened. His hand felt like a stranger's.

"I can't, " he started.

"None of us can," Zephyr said. All humor was gone. His massive body rolled his shoulders against the dampening field the way you roll against a weight that isn't going anywhere. "Wet cement. Hate this place."

The Warden was a man whose face looked like it had been carved and then left outside for several hard winters. He processed them with the hostility of someone performing a necessary unpleasantness. The guard who scanned Zephyr's card sneered and said something. Zephyr's hands clenched. Bás spoke his name, once, and the hands unclenched.

The guard who scanned Abraher's card laughed, a short, contemptuous sound, the kind that had been perfected over years of practice, and said: "Status Yellow. 'Emotion-Linked.' What's the matter, boy? Gonna cry and make it rain?"

Abraher flinched. He felt it move through him the way those words always moved through him, finding the exact right place to land. He looked at the floor. His jaw was tight.

Elara said nothing. But her hand found his arm, briefly, and pressed, and then she was looking straight ahead as if nothing had happened.

The tour of the cell block was not a tour. It was an education in what a government becomes when fear becomes doctrine.

Five levels of cells, open-plan, the sounds from every level mixing into a low, unceasing human din. The smell was the kind that you didn't forget, antiseptic failing at its job, unwashed bodies, institutional food, and underneath it all the particular smell of sustained suffering, which is not a metaphor, which is a real smell, which lives in places where people are kept in cages for what they are rather than what they've done.

A woman with bark-like skin reached through the bars. A man with faintly glowing eyes sat with his head in his hands. Thin people, skeletal people, people who had been here long enough that the institution had gotten inside them.

Elara stopped walking. Her hand came up to her mouth. She reached outward with her mind, instinctively, searching for something living that she could connect to, and found, in the far corner, a single cat, small and matted, limping across the floor. She reached for it gently, the way she always reached for injured things.

The cat hissed, flinched, and fled into the shadows. Its mind was too broken and too feral for comfort.

Elara's face crumpled, briefly, before she put it back together.

Bás noticed. He said nothing. But he slowed his pace slightly and let her walk beside him for the rest of the descent.

At the bottom level, a blast door led to a subterranean elevator, and Katerina explained, with an edge of dark reverence that she didn't seem to notice in her own voice, that below them sat Prisoner BB-0001. Titan. The reason the entire facility existed. The anti-powered state's proof of concept, its origin myth, its monster in the basement.

"He is why the Purity Doctrine is necessary," Katerina said. "He is the walking argument."

Bás tilted his head. "You speak of him as if he is a god."

"He is a devil." She said it with flat certainty. "And he is why we do not apologize for what you see above you."

A beat. Then:

"This way. Chyort's containment wing."

—

The cell was pristine, which was somehow worse. Clean surfaces, no bars, just a thick durasteel door with a viewport, and inside it a room with a single metal slab for a bed and nothing else. No water. No sink. No toilet. Nothing organic. Nothing to touch.

Bás understood the design immediately: a room built to contain a plague through the simple elimination of everything a plague needs.

"Gone," the Warden said, his voice tight with the specific fury of a man whose professional reputation was attached to this door. "The ambush, he must have been the target."

"Waste of time," Zephyr said. "Let's leave."

Bás walked past him into the cell.

"Agent Eagla, " Katerina began.

He did not turn around. He moved to the center of the room and stood very still, and the quality of his stillness was different from his usual stillness, which was already unusual. This was the stillness of someone listening to something no one else could hear.

He did not speak for almost thirty seconds.

Then he knelt.

His gloved hands moved with extreme slowness across the floor, not touching it, but hovering above it, close enough that the tips of his fingers were almost grazing the metal. His eyes, behind the mask, were the particular color of green that, in Bás Eagla, meant he was using The Mind, the ability that had no comfortable name, the one that let him see the history of everything he was near. Not clairvoyance, not psychometry, not any word that reduced it to something manageable. He simply saw, if he allowed himself to, every moment of a place or person since their beginning.

Most of the time he kept it closed. The weight of what lived in every surface, every object, every room was not something a person could carry constantly. He had learned that early. His grandfather had taught him the word for it, *iompar*, to carry, and the other word, a word his grandfather said only once, for what happened when you carried too much.

He opened it now, carefully, like a door into a dark room. He let the cell's history move through him.

It was worse than he expected.

The man had been here for a long time. Years. The early memories of the room were a texture of routine, meals delivered through a slot, the sound of the Warden's weekly inspection, the particular rhythm of days without variation that Bás recognized from his own experience of loss, of being stripped down to only the container of yourself. The room remembered this. Objects remember. Surfaces remember. The metal slab had absorbed the shape of a body spending thousands of hours in the same position, and the position was not lying down, not sleeping, it was sitting upright, cross-legged, hands on knees, the posture of someone who had decided that the only thing they could not take from him was the quality of his attention.

Then, more recently, weeks, perhaps a month, the memory of the room shifted. The routine was the same. But something underneath it had changed. The stillness of a man waiting for his own death had become the stillness of a man waiting for something else.

And the dust. Bás brought his hovering hand to rest just above the floor near the base of the slab, and he let himself see it, the microscopic architecture of it, the dead skin cells and the mites that fed on them, the ordinary biological residue of existence in a small enclosed space. It was diseased. Not randomly. The disease had structure, shape, intention. Someone had spent weeks, in the small hours between one inspection and the next, working. Practicing. Taking the only material available, his own shed cells, his own biology, and testing and refining in a space so small and a scale so invisible that none of the monitoring equipment would see it.

Bás had seen many things with The Mind. He had seen violence and grief and the long corridors of people's worst moments. This was different. This was the memory of a man who had transformed his own captivity into a laboratory. Who had used the only raw material they could not take from him, his own body's constant renewal, to build something.

He stood up.

"He was here," he said. His voice was lower than usual, and the Warden didn't say anything cutting about it. "Recently. The energy is not old, days, perhaps less." He turned, and his green eyes were doing the thing that made people instinctively step back, the brightness that meant he had seen too much and was processing it in real time. "He was not idle in this room. He used it. He practiced, with the only material

available to him, his own shed cells. The dust in this space is not just contaminated. It is a finished product. He was ready before the escape was arranged."

Katerina stood very still. "How could you possibly, "

"The trail is fresh," Bás said. "And the energy in it is not dissipating. It is, " he paused, and something crossed his face beneath the mask, something that wasn't quite fear but was the recognition of fear's appropriate object, "waiting."

The alarm went off.

Not the way alarms usually went off, the gradual escalation from beep to buzz to alert. This was instantaneous, everything at once, blood-red emergency strobes strobing through the cell block, a deafening bass-heavy klaxon that hit them physically, and from below, from far below, a sound that was not part of any alarm system.

BOOM.

BOOM.

BOOM.

Not percussion. Footsteps.

"NO!" Katerina's composure vanished completely. "Sub-Level Omega! Containment breach!"

The Warden was already in his comm, his voice stripped down to bare function: "He's out. Protocol Red Avalanche. NOW."

The cell block above them erupted. Not in the sound of alarm, but in a human sound, the specific sound of hundreds of imprisoned people who have been afraid for a very long time and have just realized, all at once, that something has changed. It was not purely terror. There was something else in it.

"Titan is LOOSE!" the Warden roared.

Gunfire from the elevator shaft. Short, panicked bursts. Then a sound that gunfire was not designed to stop. Then silence.

"RUN!" Katerina grabbed the recruits and moved. "TO THE EXIT! NOW!"

They ran. The corridors were chaos, guards moving the wrong direction, their faces carrying expressions that Abraher had only seen once before, in the orphanage, the time the building caught fire and the adults who were supposed to know what to do found out they didn't.

They skidded to a halt at the main intersection.

Something flew past them. It resolved, over a distance of roughly twenty feet, into an Iron Talon guard. He hit the concrete wall with the sound of something that should not make that sound. He didn't slide down. He just stopped, briefly pinned by the physics of impact, before dropping.

Abraher gagged. Elara caught his arm.

"Get behind me." Zephyr's voice had dropped several registers. He stepped forward, planting himself in front of the recruits, and the neon suit under the emergency lighting looked, just for a moment, less like fashion and more like a war flag.

Bás stood his ground, facing the smoke-filled red-lit corridor from which the guard had come. His hands were at his sides. His posture was the posture of a man who has decided something.

BOOM.

The floor buckled.

BOOM.

The lights swung.

BOOM.

He came out of the smoke like a continent deciding to walk. Eight and a half feet of obsidian muscle, his skin glowing faintly red from within where the energy of a hundred suppressed attacks had been stored for years. His eyes were two burning points of crimson in the dark. The dampening field that had stripped every other powered person in the building down to their bones had not touched him. He was, functionally, the reason the dampening field existed.

And on his shoulder, grinning with the giddy abandon of someone who had just stopped being afraid of everything, sat a scrawny, hollow-cheeked man in the remnants of prison clothes.

"Chyort," Bás said. Very quietly.

"Oh, Katerina!" Chyort's voice was wet and hacking and delighted. "You were so helpful! Opening all those doors for us! The diplomats were the distraction, we needed someone with clearance to walk us right through!"

Titan's red eyes found the I.S.P. team. He regarded them with the attention of something that has been caged for a long time and is now assessing the room with great deliberateness.

"THE PLAGUE WAS THE BAIT," he said. The sound of it moved through the floor.

"And now the real plague begins!" Chyort held up a vial, small and glass and dripping with something that caught the emergency light in a way that was wrong. "Titan's opened every cell on this rock! We walk out through a riot, and I give this to the water supply on the way!"

Katerina had gone white. "You were both in on it. The escape was staged from the beginning."

Titan looked at her with the expression of a man who has had a very long time to think about the people who built his cage. Then he looked at Bás and Zephyr, and something in his expression shifted, not softening, but sharpening into something more specific.

"YOU ARE NOT IN A PRISON," he said. "YOU ARE IN OUR WEAPON. AND YOU ARE TRAPPED IN HERE... WITH US."

He charged.

—

Not at the group. At Zephyr. The mathematics of the situation were clear to him: the impenetrable one first, because the impenetrable one was the one who would try to stop him with his body, and Titan had spent years learning to read a threat and remove it in the correct order.

"GET BACK!" Zephyr's voice was pure bark, no synthesis, no performance. He shoved Elara, Katerina, and Bás sideways and planted his feet and crossed his arms and took it.

The collision was not a sound you heard. It was a sound you felt in your skeleton.

Zephyr, all six-foot-seven and whatever-he-was-made-of of him, became a neon projectile. He flew the length of the corridor in a fraction of a second and hit the reinforced concrete wall at the end of it, and instead of stopping, he went through it, a man-shaped hole in solid stone, rebar bending outward around the outline of him like a portrait frame.

Titan stopped. His red eyes narrowed. He had hit a wall, and the wall had moved.

A glow of neon from inside the hole. Then Zephyr stepped back through it, brushing concrete dust off his suit with two casual swipes of his hands. His mask was cycling through expressions rapidly before settling on something that could only be described as professionally excited.

"Okay," he said. "That one almost, and I want to be precise about this, almost tickled."

Titan's stony face rearranged itself into something that was, unmistakably, a smile.

"IMPERVIOUS," he said. "INTERESTING."

He cracked his neck. It sounded like geology.

"I HAVE NOT HAD 'INTERESTING' IN A LONG, LONG TIME."

With Titan's full attention now and permanently committed to Zephyr, Chyort saw his opening. He slipped from the giant's shoulder, hit the floor running, and headed for the most obvious high-value target: Katerina. A government official. An unlock code, a hostage, a message.

He made it four steps before a pillar of shadow materialized between them.

Bás did not appear so much as arrive, the way shadows arrive, not from anywhere, just suddenly present. His arm intercepted Chyort's wrist without violence, a simple interception, and the cold that came off him made the plague-maker hiss and pull back.

"Recruits," Bás said, his voice carrying with complete clarity over the chaos.

"Katerina. Go."

Katerina went. She didn't look back.

"Elara-"

But Elara was already scanning the corridor with the systematic focus of someone running a search pattern. "Abraher," she said. "Where is Abraher?"

He was gone. In the first wave of panic, in the stampede of inmates pouring from the opened cells, the boy with the grey eyes and the storm inside him had been swallowed.

Elara looked at Bás. The look lasted less than a second but contained a full and complex conversation: I know you need me here. I'm leaving anyway. I'm sorry. Don't die.

She ran.

"Just us, then," Bás said to Chyort. His voice was completely level. This was the version of Bás that did not require Zephyr's warmth to function, the original version, the one that had existed before Base 45 and the neon rec room and the unlikely friendship. Ancient, cold, and absolutely focused.

Chyort spat and lunged.

—

The fight was asymmetric in every possible way. Chyort was feral and fast, a cornered animal moving on desperation and prison-honed survival instinct, his shiv made from a diseased bone sharp enough to cut if it got through. He was quick, genuinely quick, and he had spent years in a cell learning to fight in small spaces where you couldn't move very far.

Bás didn't fight in the corridor. He fought in the shadows.

He sank into the floor, not metaphorically, literally, his body losing its solidity and sliding downward like a reflection of himself being drawn backward, and reappeared from the wall behind Chyort, who slashed through empty air and stumbled. Bás reappeared six feet to the left. Chyort's next lunge found nothing.

"You fear the plague," Bás said, and his voice came from everywhere, from the walls and the floor and the pooling dark between the emergency lights. "But you have never seen a true nightmare."

He let the power out carefully. Not fully, he almost never used it fully, because fully was a door he was careful about opening. He targeted Chyort's mind and placed there a single image, drawn from the man's own history, from the thing Bás had seen in The Mind when his hand hovered above the floor of that cell. He showed Chyort the years. The long years in the dry room. The endless identical days. The specific quality of a silence that doesn't end.

Chyort stumbled. His hands went to his temples. He made a sound that came from somewhere older than language.

Bás moved, and a single precise kick connected with two of Chyort's ribs. The sound was the sound of small bones not tolerating the force applied to them.

Chyort screamed and reached into his rags. "Have a taste of mine!" he wheezed, and threw a small glass vial at the floor.

The gas was yellow and immediate. It came up around Bás before he could step back, and he held his breath and went intangible and moved away from it, but intangibility had limits and the gas found the edges of those limits, and by the time it cleared, his eyes were burning and his ears were ringing and the sounds of frantic, hacking footsteps were already gone.

Chyort had fled down the corridor after Katerina.

Bás stood in the dissipating cloud and assessed the situation with the practiced speed of someone who had been assessing situations for a very long time. Then he moved toward the sonic explosions that had been occurring, at regular intervals, in the adjacent wing.

—

The mess hall looked like a disagreement between geology and engineering. Half the walls were rubble. The floor had a hole in it the shape of Zephyr being thrown through it. Zephyr himself was currently airborne again, serving as a springboard off the far wall, his body absorbing the impact and redirecting it, his mask cycling through something that might charitably be described as gleeful.

"COME ON, BIG GUY! IS THAT ALL?! My grandmother hits harder and she's been dead for a long time!"

Titan, for all his fury and power and the red glow of absorbed energy surrounding him like a second skin, was... enjoying himself. It was the most disturbing thing Bás had seen all day. The "Apex Abomination" was grinning.

"MORE," Titan said, catching Zephyr's return charge and throwing him again with the easy pleasure of someone finally doing the thing they were made for. "GOOD."

Bás rose from Titan's own shadow, the shadow the giant's enormous body cast in the emergency lighting, which Bás used like a door, and drove his stiffened fingers into the back of Titan's knee with the precision of a surgeon who had done a great deal of reading.

Titan roared. He staggered. His knee bent, slightly, for exactly one second.

Then the red glow pulsed from the impact site, brighter than before, and the dent was simply gone.

Titan turned. The smile was still there, but the quality of it had changed. "KINETIC ABSORPTION," he said. "AND ADAPTIVE RESISTANCE." He flexed, and the glow brightened. "EACH STRIKE BECOMES ARMOR. EACH ATTACK, FUEL."

Zephyr landed beside Bás. They looked at each other, the green eyes and the mask-smile, and the same information passed between them in the wordless shorthand of people who have been in too many bad situations together.

"He is absorbing our attacks," Bás said. "We are feeding him."

"So we hit him harder, "

"We are feeding him, Zephyr."

A beat.

"...Right. So what's the play?"

Titan slammed his fists together, and the shockwave wasn't localized, it moved through the entire ruined mess hall, shaking the remaining walls, sending them both skidding back. "YOUR STRENGTH IS MY STRENGTH, CLOWN! THANK YOU FOR THE GIFT!"

He grabbed a ten-foot section of bulkhead and threw it like a disc.

Zephyr met it head-on, absorbed the impact, redirected the energy, and launched himself at Titan with every joule of it plus everything the mask had been storing.

"ZEPHYR, NO, "

The blow landed squarely in the center of Titan's chest. The energy that should have moved a mountain washed over him and sank into him like water into sand.

"THANK YOU," Titan said, and clapped.

Not together. One on each side of Zephyr's head.

The throw was a discus throw. A spinning, full-rotation, impossible-force discus throw that sent Zephyr through the mess hall, through the corridor, through the outer wall of Black Bastion itself.

CRACK-BOOM.

A Zephyr-shaped hole opened in the mountain.

Bás was through it in the same instant, sinking into the shadows and rising on the other side.

They were on a cliff. The prison was at the mountain's peak, and below them, hundreds of feet below, the Atlantic churned in the grey light, angry and grey and vast.

Zephyr extracted himself from a pile of rubble. His suit was unscratched. His pride was complicated.

"Okay," he panted. "He's... actually stronger than last time."

"We have to change the battlefield." Bás was already at the edge of the cliff, his back to the fight, his comm unit deep in his robes and already activated. "Benny. Come in. Authorization: Protocol Wrath of the Sea. I need you to bring him here. Now."

"Not fight him'?" Zephyr, behind him, was doing his best impression of a distraction, cartwheeling away from Titan's charge with the acrobatic flair of something that genuinely didn't care if it got hit. "WOOOO! You throw like a building inspector, rock-guy! Show me what you've actually got!"

Titan stopped. His red eyes narrowed. "I AM NOT ENTERTAINMENT."

"No, you're a symbol, right?" Zephyr landed on a high point of rubble and struck a pose. "That's what you told yourself. Revolution. Justice. Great stuff. Very inspiring." He tilted his head. "But you're in here working with a plague-rat who's poisoning the ocean, and the ocean had nothing to do with your cage, my friend. That's not justice. That's just collateral."

"SILENCE!"

The rage that word produced was disproportionate to the sentence, which meant the sentence had found something real. Titan moved, and he moved with all of it, all the absorbed energy of the entire fight, the red aura blazing, and not at Zephyr.

At the quiet one on the cliff edge.

"ENOUGH OF YOUR PHONE CALLS, SHADOW."

He raised his foot.

"SHOCKWAVE STOMP."

The cliff top fractured. Not locally, entirely, a wave of kinetic force through the stone that rippled outward from the impact point and took the edge of the cliff with it. The section where Bás was standing ceased to exist.

Bás dropped. He was already going intangible, already sinking, already moving, but Titan was faster, in this moment, with all that stolen force behind him, and the open-palmed swat connected with Bás mid-transition, hitting him at the exact moment between solid and shadow when he was most vulnerable.

The sound was small and dry and wrong.

Bás went into the air. He came down in an arc. He went into the water, hundreds of feet below, and the water closed over him, and he was gone.

Zephyr stopped moving.

The neon suit, in the storm-dark, looked like the last light in a very large room.

His mask-smile, that fixed, permanent, cheerful expression that had never once wavered in all the years anyone had known him, did not change. But something around it did. Something in the set of his enormous shoulders.

"Bás?"

Titan walked to the broken edge of the cliff and looked down at the churning black water. He watched for several seconds. Nothing surfaced.

He turned.

He laughed. Not with joy. With the particular satisfaction of something that has been waiting a very long time to prove a point.

"ONE LESS. THE SHADOW IS EXTINGUISHED."

He looked at Zephyr. His eyes were burning. "NOW, CLOWN. YOU."

Zephyr's hands began to shake. The emoji on his mask cycled through things that didn't have names and settled on something it had never displayed before.

He had been hit by things that leveled buildings and stood up smiling. He had been thrown through concrete and come back with a joke. He had faced things that should have broken him and found them, each time, a little bit fun. The not-breaking was real. The fun was real. But it wasn't the only real thing.

"You..." His voice, for the first time Bás Eagla had ever heard it, cracked.

The ocean answered.

Not Zephyr's voice, the ocean. The water at the base of the cliff began to pull back, and the sound of it was the sound from the Chilean shore, familiar now in the worst possible way, and the rumble that built from it was not from the storm.

Zephyr's mask cycled once more. It stopped on something new, something it had apparently been saving for exactly this moment.

It was awe.

"He did it," Zephyr whispered. "He actually..."

The sea rose.

A hundred feet of it, moving against gravity with the certainty of something that has never lost an argument with physics because physics remembers who was there first. It pulsed with turquoise bioluminescence, lit from within by things that lived in the deep and didn't need the sun. And cradled in a vast, careful, watery hand, like an object of extraordinary value that had been dropped and recovered,

Bás Eagla. His dark robes trailing water. His skull mask still in place, one degree askew. His body limp and still.

Thaldrim, the Ocean's Wrath, had arrived. And the first thing he did was not look at Titan. He looked at the body in his hand.

He placed him. The water carried Bás to the stone with a gentleness that was, given the scale of the being doing it, the most precise thing Bás had ever seen anything do. The water softened and deposited him on the cliff, safely back from the edge, and withdrew.

Zephyr was there before the water finished retreating. He hit his knees on the stone beside his partner without a thought about the impact. His hand went to Bás's chest.

Breathing. Barely, and labored, and wrong in a way that suggested broken things inside, but breathing.

"Bás." Zephyr's voice, this close, with no one to perform for, was just a voice. "Bás. C'mon. You can't die. I'll have to do paperwork. Do you understand what I'm saying to you? Paperwork. Actual paperwork."

He kept his hand on his partner's chest, tracking the rise and fall of it, and did not move.

Thaldrim turned to Titan.

His full height was visible now, standing on the cliff face with the ocean at his back. He was taller than Titan. Not by much. But enough.

"I AM THALDRIM," he said. "AND I AM THE WRATH OF THIS SEA."

Titan, who had faced armies and orbital weapons and the combined military might of a modern state, looked at the being in front of him and recognized, for the first time in a very long time, something that was in the same weight class.

"ANOTHER," he said. "AND YOU SMELL OF THE OLD WORLD."

"YOU USED MY DOMAIN AS A TOOL," Thaldrim said. "YOU POISONED MY WATERS FOR YOUR PERSONAL RECKONING WITH A HANDFUL OF MEN WHO BUILT YOUR CAGE."

"IF THE SEA MUST DIE FOR ME TO BE FREE," Titan said, his red aura blazing, "THEN LET IT DIE."

The sea behind Thaldrim exploded upward in a five-hundred-foot column of pure elemental fury. The sky, which had been Abraher's storm, obeyed Thaldrim's rage and tore itself open.

"YOU HAVE FORFEITED YOUR RIGHT TO BREATHE."

Thaldrim crossed fifty feet in a single step and grabbed.

Not a punch. Not a strike that Titan could absorb and redirect. A grip. A constant, crushing, elemental force wrapped around Titan's obsidian neck, and the kinetic absorption that had made Titan effectively invincible against every weapon ever brought against him had no answer for sustained pressure that didn't stop.

Titan's red eyes widened for the first time. He tried to absorb the grip. The grip did not care.

Thaldrim lifted him off his feet.

The Mountain That Walks, the Living Juggernaut, the Apex Abomination, the walking argument for why the Purity Doctrine was necessary, dangled.

What followed was not a fight. It was a demonstration.

Thaldrim moved across the Atlantic at speeds that turned the ocean's surface into a white blur, and he used Titan's body as the prow. Into the water, under it, through it, up through the surface long enough for one gasping breath, back under. The deep was not Titan's element. The pressure at the depths Thaldrim knew was absolute, and adaptive resistance is a remarkable ability, but adaptation takes time, and the ocean has more of it than you do.

By the time they stopped, in the middle of the Atlantic, miles from land in every direction, Titan was hanging in Thaldrim's grip the way the word defeat looks when it still has pride.

"I... AM... TITAN," he said. "I AM RESISTANCE..."

"YOU ARE A PEBBLE THAT THINKS IT IS A MOUNTAIN," Thaldrim said. And then, with the cold deliberateness of something ancient and utterly without hurry:

"YOU WISHED TO BE A SYMBOL. A MEMORY. VERY WELL. I WILL GIVE YOU EXACTLY WHAT YOU WISHED FOR."

The tentacles came from below. Pearlescent white, impossibly large, unhurried in the way of things that exist at depths where time moves differently. One for each arm. One for each leg.

Titan's red eyes, for the first time, showed something that was not rage. It was the recognition of a specific kind of forever.

Thaldrim released his grip.

The tentacles pulled. There was no struggle. There was a THWOOMP of displaced water and Titan was gone, pulled into the black below, and the surface closed over him like a thought that had been reconsidered.

A few bubbles. Then nothing.

—

In the recreation yard of Black Bastion, it was raining.

The yard was a hundred feet of concrete and steel mesh, open to the sky. The sky, through the mesh, was Abraher's sky, the storm he'd been failing to hold back ever since the dampening field had been shattered by Titan's escape. He was on his hands and knees on the wet concrete, eyes shut, doing the thing he always did when the panic became absolute: trying to make himself small enough that the world would stop noticing him.

He'd been separated in the stampede. He'd run without knowing where he was running. He'd ended up here, in this dead-end square of empty yard, and his power had felt the ceiling lift when the dampening system failed, and it had done what it always did when he was afraid enough: filled the sky with itself.

Chyort found him because Chyort was looking for anything available, and Abraher was available.

"Well, well, well." The wet, hacking voice came from the broken gate. "A straggler."

Abraher's head snapped up. He scrambled backward, the wet concrete scraping his palms. "No. Get away. Please."

Chyort moved with the unhurried confidence of someone who has already decided how this goes. He crossed the yard and grabbed Abraher by the hood and yanked, and Abraher went down, and Chyort kicked him, hard, in the ribs.

Abraher curled around the impact.

"Running," Chyort said, walking alongside him, his voice dropping into the particular register of someone who has done this before and enjoyed it. "Just like you ran from the fight. Just like you've always run." Another kick. "You're a coward. A little scared boy who calls himself a hero."

Abraher was trying to crawl. His hands slipped on the wet concrete. The rain was coming down harder.

"A loser," Chyort said. "No one important. A worthless, sniveling kid."

He stopped.

"A mistake."

The rain stopped. Not because it had run out. Because every molecule of water vapor in the sky above the recreation yard held perfectly still.

Abraher's crawling slowed. Then stopped.

He'd heard that word so many times. In so many voices. In the orphanage from the older boys, in his own head in the dark, in the small hours of whatever room he was sleeping in that year. Mistake. He'd learned to hear it and keep moving, to let it pass through him and out the other side, to not let it find purchase.

It found purchase.

"I said," he said. His voice was very quiet. His hands, on the wet concrete, were no longer shaking. "Stop."

"Or what?" Chyort laughed. "You'll cry and make it rain? Oh, wait."

Abraher pushed himself up.

His face was wet from the rain and from crying and from the concrete, and his eyes when he opened them were the color of a storm after the decision has been made. He looked at the man in front of him, the hollow cheeks, the rotted teeth, the amused cruelty of someone who had never once in his life been afraid of a boy like Abraher,

and every year of being a boy like Abraher, every word like mistake, every night that had started this one, coalesced into a single sound that started somewhere around his diaphragm and came out of him like weather.

"I SAID STOP."

The sky answered.

It wasn't a branching bolt. It was a column, vertical, absolute, a spear of concentrated atmospheric electricity guided by the most precise instrument in meteorology, which was Abraher's furious grief. It came down through the mesh of the recreation yard and struck Chyort directly, and only Chyort, on the crown of his head.

The world went white. Abraher was thrown backward by the concussion of air and landed hard and lay still, his ears making a sound like the space between radio stations.

When his vision cleared, Chyort was standing. Rigid, eyes wide and empty, smoke rising from his hair in a thin, philosophical wisp.

Then blood. From the hairline. From the nose. From the eyes, which were no longer looking at anything.

He toppled sideways. He hit the concrete with the flat, finalizing sound of something that was over.

Abraher looked at what he had done.

He looked at it for a long time. The rain returned, ordinary rain, nothing to do with him anymore, washing the concrete around the body.

"ABRAHER!"

Elara came through the gate at a dead run, her red hair soaked flat against her face, her breath coming in ragged pulls. She stopped when she saw the yard. She took in the smell, ozone, burnt hair, rain, and the body, and then Abraher, on his hands and knees, staring.

He looked up at her.

His stormy grey eyes were empty of everything except the specific and terrible knowledge of having crossed a line that doesn't have a crossing-back.

"I..." he started. Then: "Elara. I... I killed him. I killed him."

She moved before she decided to move. She crossed the yard and dropped to her knees in front of him and grabbed him, and when she pulled his head to her shoulder, it wasn't a consolation gesture or a professional thing, it was the same instinct she'd had toward every broken thing she'd ever found in the wild. This is alive. Hold it. Don't let it go.

Abraher came apart in her arms.

Not fear. Not the hyperventilating panic from earlier. Something deeper and worse, the grief of a person who has spent their whole life being told they're too much, who has spent years trying to be less, trying to turn the volume down, trying to be controllable, and who has just discovered that the thing they were most afraid of being, they were.

"I didn't mean, it was, he said, I just wanted him to stop, "

"I know," Elara said. Her voice was shaking and she didn't try to hide it. "I know. I know you did."

She held him. The rain fell on both of them. He shook, and she held him through it, and the storm above them, his storm, the one that had answered his worst moment, gradually, gradually, began to clear.

An explosion from outside the yard shook the ground. The fight on the cliff. Still happening.

Elara pulled back and found his face with both hands. Her dark eyes were fierce and wet.

"Listen to me. You did what you had to do. He was going to hurt more people. That is true." She waited until he focused on her. "And Bás and Zephyr are still out there. And we have to go. Now."

Abraher looked at his hands. He looked at them for a long moment.

Then he let Elara pull him to his feet.

"Stay with me," she said. She kept her hand in his. "Stay with me."

—

On the cliff, with Titan gone and the sea settling back to something resembling itself, Zephyr was trying to get his partner to eat a candy bar.

"It's sugar, Bás. It's happy. We saved the ocean. Kinda. You almost died but you didn't. This is a candy bar occasion."

Bás was sitting upright against a chunk of rubble, his mask slightly off-center, his breathing shallow but present. His hands were in his lap. He'd stopped arguing about being horizontal approximately thirty seconds after Zephyr had moved him there, which Zephyr understood was a measure of how much he actually hurt.

"I have twelve broken ribs," Bás said. "A candy bar is not going to address twelve broken ribs."

"No, but it'll address your face, which is doing the thing it does when you're trying not to admit something is bad."

Bás looked at him for a moment through the mask. Then he took the candy bar.

Elara arrived through the smoking hole in the prison wall with Abraher's hand still in hers. She stopped when she saw Bás sitting up, and the relief on her face was immediate and enormous and exactly as composed as everything else she did, which is to say: not very.

Abraher stopped when he saw Thaldrim standing at the edge of the cliff, looking out at the water.

Thaldrim's attention tracked to the sound of them arriving, the way attention that large and old moves, slowly, completely, without wasted motion. His turquoise eyes found the recruits. They found the space where Chyort was not.

"THE PLAGUE-RAT," he said. "WHERE IS HE."

Katerina, who had found her way back from whatever corridor she'd fled down and was standing off to one side looking like a woman who had exited through the other side of an experience into something harder and more honest, opened her mouth.

But a sound from beside Elara stopped everyone.

Abraher had heard Thaldrim's question. He had heard the "where is he" and the implied justice and the promise of an ocean floor. And whatever was holding him together, the thin, fragile thing he'd assembled in the recreation yard, simply gave

way. A whimper escaped him. He pulled away from Elara and fled back through the prison door, and the sobs that followed were the kind that go through walls.

Elara looked at Bás.

Bás looked at her.

"Recruit," he said. Quiet. "What happened."

She told them. All of it. Slowly and precisely, the way she did everything. When she finished, the cliff was silent except for the wind and the distant sound of crying.

Thaldrim's enormous brow was furrowed. The trident's butt rested on the stone. His turquoise eyes looked in the direction Abraher had gone.

A low sound built in his chest. It was not a rumble of anger. It was a laugh.

"HA. THE STORM ANSWERED THE BOY." The laugh was deep and genuine and carried a respect in it that was unmistakable. "THE LAND-RAT POISONED THE SEA, AND THE SKY STRUCK HIM DOWN. A FITTING JUSTICE."

He looked at Elara directly. "THE BOY DID NOT WAIT FOR MY JUSTICE. HE TOOK HIS OWN. HE HAS THE HEART OF A TEMPEST. TELL HIM."

A pause.

"TELL HIM THE OCEAN KNOWS HIS GRIEF. AND APPROVES."

Katerina stepped forward, her white suit destroyed, her practiced persona very far away. "I have a transport. We need to leave. The, there will need to be..." She stopped trying to end that sentence. "The transport is ready."

Bás nodded. Every degree of movement showed.

"Zephyr. Get the boy."

—

Zephyr found Abraher by the main gate, sitting against the outer wall of the prison in the rain, arms around his knees. He sat down beside him without announcement, which was unusual for Zephyr. He didn't say anything for a moment.

Then: "You did good."

Abraher said nothing.

"I know that's not how it feels," Zephyr said. "Trust me, I know. When you have, when you're built the way we're built, the first time you really use it on something and it works exactly as advertised, it's, " he stopped. "It doesn't feel like a victory. It feels like a door you can't close."

Abraher looked up at him. His eyes were red and raw. "Does it ever..."

"Get easier?" Zephyr was quiet for a long moment. Longer than Abraher had ever seen him quiet. "No. But you get, you get better at carrying it. And you're not carrying it alone. Okay?"

Abraher looked at the giant neon figure sitting in the rain beside him, and something in him that had been braced since the recreation yard softened, very slightly.

"Okay," he said.

Zephyr stood up and offered him an enormous hand, and Abraher took it, and was helped to his feet.

—

The black armored SUV carried them back to the airfield through a Nova Palma that looked exactly as it had on the way in, orderly, clean, its propaganda banners bright in the afternoon sun, and the gap between how it looked and what they had seen underneath it sat in the vehicle with them like a passenger.

Abraher watched the banners go past. He did not sink down in his seat.

At the airfield, Katerina stood on the tarmac as the jet's steps descended. She looked like someone who had gone into a system this morning with certain beliefs about how the world worked and had come out the other side without them.

"The Sovereign State of Mallorca thanks you," she said. "For your assistance. The situation will be... managed. Narratively."

"You mean you will take credit for the resolution and erase our involvement," Bás said. He was standing with visible effort, Zephyr close enough to catch him without making it obvious.

"I mean your flight is cleared, Agent Eagla." She paused. Her eyes moved to Abraher, then to Elara. Then back to Bás. Something moved through her expression that had not been there that morning. Not guilt, exactly. The beginning of the question that might lead to guilt, in time. "A pleasure to guide you."

She walked away, already on her phone, already rebuilding.

The jet climbed through the Mallorcan sky and broke through the cloud cover into the orange light above it, and the island below became a shape and then a smudge and then nothing.

Benny's voice came over the comm, warm and relieved and slightly too loud as always: "All green on my board! Well, four green, one turquoise. You're all alive! Mostly! Chuckles is celebrating."

"Benny," Bás said.

"Yes?"

"Twelve broken ribs."

"Oh. Oh dear. I'll have the medical bay ready. Also, " a pause, and under the lightness, something genuine, "good work, all of you. Really."

Silence. Then Zephyr, from across the cabin:

"So. Candy bar or not, Bás?"

"I already ate your candy bar."

"You, when did you, that was my candy bar!"

"You offered it."

"I offered it as a gesture of care! Not as actual candy bar transfer!"

Abraher, for the first time since the recreation yard, made a sound that might have been the beginning of a laugh. It was brief and quickly swallowed. But Elara, sitting beside him, heard it, and the tight thing in her chest loosened the smallest amount.

She looked out the window at the clouds below them, white and clean and completely indifferent to everything that had happened underneath them today. She looked at them for a long time.

Then she looked at Abraher, who was looking at his hands again, but differently now. Not with horror. With something more like curiosity. The careful examination of someone trying to understand what they are.

He became aware of her watching him. He looked up. He didn't look away.

"Thank you," he said. "For coming to find me."

"Of course," she said.

They flew on through the orange light, westward, toward the Andes and the base carved into them and the rec room with its neon walls, and whatever ordinary evening waited on the other side of all of this. The jet was a silver thread in a very large sky.

—

KATERINA. She stands at the edge of the airfield watching the jet become a speck. Her phone is in her hand, the call already dialed. Her face is hard and efficient and performing none of the things that are actually moving through her mind. "The prison is compromised. We manage the narrative. Blame the escaped prisoners. The I.S.P. agents were never here." A pause. "Begin the purges." She walks back to the waiting car. Her white suit is stained. She does not look down at it.

THALDRIM. Middle of the Atlantic. The storm has passed, Abraher's storm, untethered from its source, dissipating now over open water. Thaldrim stands alone on the surface, which barely registers his weight, which is how it always is. The water around him is beginning to clear, the artificial virus dying in the clean open sea without its creator. He can feel it, the way you feel a wound beginning to close. He looks at the sky for a moment. He nods, once, to no one. He sinks.

TITAN. Miles below. In the absolute black. In the pressure that makes steel behave differently. His red eyes are the only light and they illuminate nothing. His adaptive resistance is working, has been working since the moment he arrived, and the pressure that should be crushing him is instead becoming him, and he will survive this, and he knows it, and it does not help at all. He has time. He has nothing but time. The deep ocean is patient in a way that makes his years of imprisonment look like an afternoon.

BENNY. Base 45. His feet are on the desk. Chuckles is on the console wearing the foil hat, watching the four green biosignatures moving steadily westward across his screen. Benny looks at them for a long moment. Then he laughs, a real laugh, the kind that comes from somewhere below strategy and performance, and reaches over and straightens Chuckles's hat.

"Would you look at that," he says quietly. "All of them. Alive."

He looks at the recruits' signals for a moment. He looks at the red one, Abraher's, yellow on the SSM registry and something else entirely on his. Then he closes the file.

"Not recruits anymore," he says. To Chuckles. To the room. To himself.

Inside the jet, Bás Eagla is not sleeping. His mask is on and his eyes are open and he is looking at the ceiling with the particular quality of attention he uses on things he is trying to understand. He has twelve broken ribs and he was dead for approximately four seconds in the Atlantic before Thaldrim's hand found him and he is alive, and he is thinking about that. About the strange arithmetic of it. About the moment in the cell when he opened The Mind and felt the shape of what the man had made of his captivity.

He is thinking about the difference between surviving and living.

Zephyr is watching him, from across the aisle, and not saying anything. Which, for Zephyr, is its own kind of language.

Abraher has his face turned to the window. His hands are in his lap, open, palms up, not bracing against anything, not clenched around anything. Just open. The clouds below them catch the last light of the day and turn gold, and the sky above them is the deep blue that comes just before stars, and the jet carries them home.

—

Is this the end?

Or only the beginning of something larger?

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